SkillNavora

STAGE 7 HANDBOOK

Stage 7: Professional and entrepreneurial readiness

Outcome: Prepare for employment and independent business.
Topics: FDE interviews, Architecture presentations, Customer discovery, Client demos, Agency packaging, SaaS MVP, Sales.

From Non-Coder to Enterprise AI Builder: Learn, Build, Deploy, Get Hired and Launch Your AI Business.

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Financial figures are hypothetical examples, not advice.

Stage 7: Professional and entrepreneurial readiness

Outcome: Prepare for employment and independent business

This handbook covers each topic of Stage 7 with a definition, why it matters, how it works, step-by-step instructions, example code or templates, common mistakes, interview questions with answers, a hands-on exercise and official resources.

Topics in this stage

1. FDE interviews
2. Architecture presentations
3. Customer discovery
4. Client demos
5. Agency packaging
6. SaaS MVP
7. Sales

STAGE 7 · TOPIC 1

FDE interviews

DEFINITION

> FDE interviews test whether you can build working software, design AI systems, and work directly with customers. Typical rounds: recruiter screen, coding (Python/SQL), practical AI build or take-home, system design (often an AI or integration system), a customer scenario or role-play, and behavioural questions about ownership.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Companies hiring FDEs (AI labs, data platforms, consultancies) look for people who combine engineering depth with customer judgement. Preparing for each round type, with real projects to discuss, is the fastest path to offers.

HOW IT WORKS

- Coding: data manipulation, APIs, debugging, sometimes algorithms; clarity and testing matter as much as speed.
- AI build: build a small LLM feature (RAG, extraction, agent) in a few hours and explain trade-offs.
- System design: requirements → architecture → data flow → model choice → evaluation → security → scaling → cost.
- Customer scenario: discover needs from a vague request, push back on unrealistic asks, explain trade-offs plainly.
- Behavioural (STAR): ownership, ambiguity, conflict, failure, influence without authority.
- Portfolio: 2–3 deployed projects with READMEs, demos and measured results.

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Read 10 current FDE job descriptions and list repeated skills.

2. Practise 30 Python and 30 SQL problems (practical, not only puzzles).
3. Build and deploy two AI projects (RAG with evaluation; an agent with tools and approval).
4. Prepare 6 STAR stories (ownership, failure, conflict, customer, ambiguity, learning).
5. Do 5 mock system designs out loud with a timer.
6. Practise a customer role-play: 'Our CEO wants an AI agent to handle all support.'

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

```
STAR ANSWER TEMPLATE
Situation: one or two sentences of context (customer, problem, stakes).
Task:      what you were responsible for.
Action:    the specific steps YOU took (technical and people), including trade-offs.
Result:    measurable outcome (time saved, accuracy, revenue, adoption) and what you learned.

SYSTEM DESIGN OUTLINE (45 minutes)
1. Clarify goals, users, volumes, constraints (data location, latency, budget)   5 min
2. High-level architecture and data flow diagram                                 10 min
3. AI design: model choice, prompts/context, RAG or tools, evaluation plan       10 min
4. Integrations, security, permissions, human-in-the-loop                         8 min
5. Scaling, monitoring, cost estimate, failure handling                           8 min
6. Risks, phased rollout, success metrics                                         4 min
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Jumping into design before clarifying requirements.
- Talking only about technology, never about customer outcomes.
- Projects with no deployment, evaluation or measured results.
- Overclaiming team work as personal work.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. Design an AI assistant that answers employees' HR questions for a 20,000-person company.

A. Clarify scope, languages, channels and sensitive topics; ingest HR policies with permission metadata; RAG with citations and hybrid search; SSO and access control by employee group; escalation to HR for personal cases; evaluation set from real questions; monitoring of feedback, cost and gaps; phased rollout by region.

Q. A customer says the pilot 'doesn't work'. What do you do?

A. Ask for specific examples, look at logs and traces for those cases, separate expectation gaps from defects, agree measurable success criteria, fix the top failure causes, and share before/after results.

Q. Why do you want to be an FDE?

A. Give a genuine answer linking your enjoyment of building with your interest in customer impact, backed by a story where you owned a problem end to end.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Record yourself doing one system design and one customer role-play, review the recordings, and improve your structure and clarity.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- SkillNavora interview handbook https://skillnavora.in/questions.html
- System Design Primer (GitHub) https://github.com/donnemartin/system-design-primer
- DataCamp: what is a forward deployed engineer https://www.datacamp.com/blog/what-is-forward-deployed-engineer

- OpenAI careers https://openai.com/careers/search/

Architecture presentations

DEFINITION

> An architecture presentation explains a proposed or built system to technical and business stakeholders: the problem, the design, the data flows, the key decisions and trade-offs, security, cost and risks, and asks for a decision.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Enterprise projects only proceed after architecture and security reviews. Clear presentations win approval faster and build trust with CTOs, CISOs and enterprise architects.

HOW IT WORKS

- Start with the business problem and success metrics.
- Show a context diagram (system and its users/external systems), then a container diagram (apps, services, databases, model providers) using the C4 model.
- Walk through one request end to end (data flow), marking where data is stored and which boundaries it crosses.
- Explain key decisions as ADRs: options considered, choice, reasons, consequences.
- Cover non-functional requirements: security, privacy, availability, latency, scalability, cost.
- End with risks, mitigations, rollout plan and the decision you need.

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Draft the one-sentence purpose and the decision you need.
2. Draw context and container diagrams (draw.io, Excalidraw, Mermaid).
3. Write 3–5 ADRs for major choices (model provider, hosting, retrieval approach, agent autonomy).
4. Prepare a data-flow slide for the most sensitive flow.
5. Prepare a cost estimate with assumptions.
6. Rehearse a 15-minute version and a 2-minute executive version.

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

````
ARCHITECTURE DECISION RECORD (ADR) TEMPLATE
Title:     ADR-007 Use a managed vector database for policy search
Status:    Proposed | Accepted | Superseded
Context:   20,000 documents, permission filtering, < 2 s answers, team of 2 engineers.
Options:   (a) pgvector in existing PostgreSQL  (b) managed vector DB  (c) cloud search service
Decision:  (a) pgvector - keeps data in the existing database and region, supports metadata filters,
           no new vendor review; revisit above 5M chunks.
Consequences: + simpler operations and security review; - we tune indexes ourselves.

SLIDE ORDER (15 min)
1 Problem and success metrics  2 Context diagram  3 Container diagram  4 Request walk-through
5 Data and security  6 Key decisions (ADRs)  7 Cost and scaling  8 Risks and rollout  9 Decision needed

```mermaid
flowchart LR
  U[Employee] ⟶|SSO| W[Web app]
  W ⟶ A[FastAPI service]
  A ⟶ R[(pgvector index)]
  A ⟶ M[Model provider in-region]
````
````

```
  A ──► L[(Audit log)]
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Diagrams with dozens of unlabeled boxes.
- Hiding risks or costs until asked.
- No clear ask at the end.
- Using vendor jargon with business audiences.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. How do you present a design to a CISO?

A. Lead with data flows and trust boundaries, data classification and residency, identity and access, encryption, logging and audit, AI-specific risks and controls, third-party providers, and incident response.

Q. What is the C4 model?

A. A way to diagram software at four zoom levels: context, containers, components and code, so each audience sees the right level of detail.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Prepare and deliver a 15-minute architecture presentation of your RAG or agent project, with diagrams, three ADRs and a cost estimate.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- C4 model https://c4model.com/
- ADR GitHub organisation https://adr.github.io/
- Mermaid diagrams https://mermaid.js.org/
- Microsoft Azure Architecture Center https://learn.microsoft.com/azure/architecture/

Customer discovery

DEFINITION

> Customer discovery is the structured process of understanding a customer's goals, current processes, pain points, systems, data and constraints before proposing a solution, through interviews, observation and data review.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Most failed AI projects solve the wrong problem or ignore constraints (data access, security, adoption). Good discovery lets an FDE pick a valuable, feasible first use case and set measurable success criteria.

HOW IT WORKS

- Prepare: research the company, industry and stakeholders; draft hypotheses.
- Interview business owners (goals, metrics, budget), users (daily work, frustrations), IT/security (systems, data, rules).
- Ask about past behaviour and real examples, not opinions about hypothetical features.
- Observe the process; collect sample data and documents (with permission).
- Quantify: volumes, time per task, error rates, costs.
- Summarise: problem statement, current vs future process, requirements, constraints, success metrics, risks; confirm with the customer.

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Send an agenda and pre-read questions before the meeting.
2. Run 5–8 interviews across roles using the question bank below.
3. Map the current process (swimlanes) and mark pain points.
4. Score candidate use cases on value, feasibility, risk and data readiness.
5. Write a discovery summary and agree on the first use case and success metrics.
6. Propose a time-boxed proof of concept.

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

```
DISCOVERY QUESTION BANK
Goals:        What outcome matters most this year? How is it measured today?
Process:      Walk me through the last time you handled one of these requests, step by step.
Pain:         Where does work wait, get repeated or go wrong? What does that cost?
Volume:       How many per day/month? Peaks? How long does each take?
Data:         Where does the information live? Who owns it? Can it leave your network?
Systems:      Which systems are involved (CRM, ERP, email, documents)? APIs available?
Risk:         What happens if the answer is wrong? Which decisions must a person make?
Security:     Data classification, residency, approved AI providers, review process?
Adoption:     Who will use it daily? What would make them stop using it?
Success:      In 90 days, what would make this a clear success?
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Pitching a solution in the first meeting.
- Talking only to executives, never to daily users.

- Ignoring security and data access until late.
- No written summary, so expectations drift.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. How do you choose the first AI use case with a customer?
A. Score candidates on business value, frequency, data availability, technical feasibility, risk and ease of measurement; choose one that is valuable, low-risk and measurable within weeks to build trust.

Q. A stakeholder asks for 'an AI agent that does everything'. How do you respond?
A. Acknowledge the goal, ask for concrete examples and metrics, break it into specific tasks, propose starting with the highest-value, lowest-risk task with clear success criteria, and outline the path to broader scope.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Run a mock discovery with a friend acting as a clinic owner, produce a process map, a scored use-case list and a one-page discovery summary.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- Y Combinator: how to talk to users https://www.ycombinator.com/library/6g-how-to-talk-to-users
- The Mom Test https://www.momtestbook.com/
- Strategyzer: value proposition canvas https://www.strategyzer.com/library/the-value-proposition-canvas

Client demos

DEFINITION

> A client demo shows a working solution solving the customer's own problem with realistic data, in a story that connects features to outcomes, followed by evidence (evaluation results) and a clear next step.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Demos move projects forward: they win pilots, unlock budgets and build user excitement. A failed or generic demo can stall a deal for months.

HOW IT WORKS

- Know the audience and the decision they must make.
- Use their data or realistic synthetic data in their format and language.
- Tell a story: today's pain → the new flow → the outcome.
- Show limits honestly: what the system does when it is unsure (hand-off, citations).
- Back the demo with numbers: accuracy on their test set, time per task, cost.
- End with a concrete next step (pilot scope, dates, owners).

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Write the demo script: 3 scenarios (common case, hard case, 'I don't know' case).
2. Prepare data and reset scripts so the demo starts clean.
3. Rehearse twice; time it to 15 minutes plus questions.
4. Prepare a backup video in case of network problems.
5. Bring a one-page summary of results and next steps.
6. After the demo, send notes and the agreed next steps within 24 hours.

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

```
DEMO SCRIPT (15 minutes)
0-2   Their problem in their words + today's numbers (e.g. 4-hour lead response)
2-5   Scenario 1: common enquiry → extraction, match, suggested reply, CRM update
5-8   Scenario 2: messy enquiry (Hinglish, missing budget) → asks a clarifying question
8-10  Scenario 3: out-of-scope question → says it cannot answer, hands to an agent
10-12 Evidence: accuracy on 100 of their past enquiries, response time, cost per lead
12-15 Pilot proposal: scope, 4-week plan, success metrics, what we need from them
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Demoing features instead of the customer's workflow.
- Live-coding or untested changes before the demo.
- Hiding failure cases, then being surprised by them.
- No next step agreed at the end.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. How do you handle a demo that breaks live?

A. Stay calm, explain briefly what happened, switch to the backup recording or another scenario, and follow up with a fix and a short recording.

Q. How do you make a demo convincing for executives?
A. Use their data, show the before/after in time and money, keep it short, show safeguards, and propose a measurable pilot.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Prepare and record a 10-minute demo of your real-estate or education project with three scenarios and an evidence slide.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- Y Combinator: how to demo https://www.ycombinator.com/library/4b-how-to-demo-your-product
- Loom (recording demos) https://www.loom.com/

Agency packaging

DEFINITION

> Agency packaging turns AI automation skills into clear, sellable service offers: a defined niche, problems solved, deliverables, timeline, price, and ongoing support, so clients can understand and buy quickly.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Vague offers ('we do AI') are hard to sell and lead to scope creep. Packaged offers make sales easier, delivery repeatable and margins healthier, and become the base for a later SaaS product.

HOW IT WORKS

- Niche: one industry and role (real-estate agency owners, coaching institutes, clinics).
- Offer ladder: paid audit → fixed-scope build → monthly retainer (support, improvements, reporting).
- Each package lists the outcome, deliverables, timeline, client responsibilities, exclusions and price.
- Pricing anchored on value (hours saved, leads converted) with a margin over delivery costs (your time, tools, model usage).
- Proof: case studies with numbers, demos and testimonials (with permission).
- Contracts: statement of work, acceptance criteria, payment terms, data protection and IP.

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Pick a niche and list the top 5 costly, repetitive problems.
2. Design an audit, two builds and a retainer.
3. Estimate your delivery hours and tool costs for each; set prices with a healthy margin (hypothetical numbers until validated).
4. Write a one-page offer sheet and a proposal template.
5. Build one demo per package.
6. Test the offers with 10 prospects and adjust.

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

```
OFFER SHEET (example, all prices hypothetical)
Niche: Real-estate agencies with 5-50 agents

1. Lead Response Audit - 1 week - INR 15,000
   Review lead sources, response times, CRM data; report with top 3 automation opportunities and ROI
estimate.

2. 60-Second Lead Response System - 3 weeks - INR 1,20,000
   Website + portal + WhatsApp intake, AI qualification and reply drafts, CRM sync, agent dashboard,
   training session, 30 days support. Client provides: CRM access, WhatsApp Business account, listings
data.
   Excludes: paid ads, new website.

3. Growth Retainer - monthly - INR 25,000
   Monitoring, prompt and workflow improvements, monthly report (response time, conversion, cost),
   up to 6 hours of changes. AI usage billed at cost.
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Selling custom projects with unlimited scope.
- Pricing by hours only, ignoring value and model costs.
- No written exclusions and acceptance criteria.
- Too many niches at once.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. How do you price an automation project?

A. Estimate the client's value (time saved, revenue gained), your delivery effort and running costs; price the build as a fixed fee that is a fraction of first-year value with a healthy margin, and charge a retainer for ongoing support and improvement.

Q. Why start with a paid audit?

A. It qualifies serious clients, funds discovery work, produces a concrete plan and ROI estimate, and usually converts into the build.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Create a complete offer sheet, proposal template and statement of work for one niche, and review them with a potential client.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- HubSpot Academy (sales) https://academy.hubspot.com/
- n8n workflow templates https://n8n.io/workflows/
- SkillNavora Master Freelancing https://skillnavora.in/master-freelancing.html

SaaS MVP

DEFINITION

> A SaaS minimum viable product is the smallest subscription product that solves one painful job end to end for a specific customer segment, well enough that they use it repeatedly and will pay for it.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Agencies and FDEs often notice the same solution requested by many customers. Turning it into an MVP tests whether a scalable product business exists before investing months of work.

HOW IT WORKS

- Problem and segment: one job, one customer type, validated in discovery and agency work.
- Core loop: the few steps a user repeats to get value (for example upload documents → ask → get cited answers).
- Must-haves: sign-up, organisation, the core loop, basic billing, essential security; everything else waits.
- Build fast with proven tools (React/Lovable, FastAPI or Supabase functions, PostgreSQL, Stripe/Razorpay).
- Launch to 5–10 design partners; measure activation, weekly use, retention and willingness to pay.
- Iterate weekly from usage data and interviews.

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Write the problem, segment and core loop on one page.
2. List features; cut everything not needed for the core loop.
3. Build the MVP in 4–6 weeks.
4. Onboard design partners personally; watch them use it.
5. Track activation and weekly active organisations; interview users every week.
6. Decide after 8–12 weeks: double down, change direction or stop.

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

```
MVP SCOPE CANVAS
Segment:        Coaching institutes with 200-2,000 students
Painful job:    Answering repeated student doubts outside class hours
Core loop:      Teacher uploads notes → students ask → cited answers → teacher sees confusion report
Must-have:      Org sign-up, teacher upload, student login, RAG answers with citations, weekly report,
paid plan
Later:          Quizzes, mobile app, WhatsApp, multilingual voice, LMS integration
Success (8 wk): 5 paying institutes, 40% of students active weekly, 90% answer accuracy on teacher-
graded set
Pricing test:   INR 20 per student per month (hypothetical; validate with customers)
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Building for every segment at once.
- Spending months on features before any user.
- Free pilots with no path to payment.
- Not measuring retention.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. How do you decide what goes into an MVP?

A. Include only what is needed for the target user to complete the core loop and get value, plus the minimum for security, billing and support; validate everything else with real users later.

Q. What signals product-market fit early?

A. Users return weekly without prompting, they would be very disappointed to lose it, they pay or expand, and they refer others.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Write an MVP scope canvas for a product idea from your projects and build a clickable prototype or working MVP of its core loop.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- Y Combinator Startup School https://www.startupschool.org/
- Lovable docs https://docs.lovable.dev/
- Supabase docs https://supabase.com/docs
- Stripe billing docs https://docs.stripe.com/billing

Sales

DEFINITION

> Sales for AI services and SaaS is the process of finding the right prospects, understanding their problems, showing value with evidence, handling objections, agreeing scope and price, and closing, then expanding through results.

WHY IT MATTERS

> Whether you run an agency, a SaaS or work as an FDE supporting sales, revenue depends on turning conversations into signed work. Technical people who can sell honestly are rare and valuable.

HOW IT WORKS

- Ideal customer profile (ICP): who has the problem, budget and authority.
- Prospecting: referrals, LinkedIn, content, communities, partnerships, events, targeted email.
- Discovery call: qualify need, impact, decision-maker, timeline and budget (frameworks such as BANT or MEDDIC).
- Demo and proposal: tailored to their problem, with ROI estimate and clear scope.
- Objection handling: price, trust, security, timing, 'we can build it ourselves'.
- Pipeline management: stages, next steps and follow-ups tracked in a CRM; review weekly.

STEP-BY-STEP

1. Define your ICP and write a list of 50 target companies.
2. Write a short, specific outreach message for each segment.
3. Book discovery calls; use the discovery question bank.
4. Send tailored proposals within 48 hours.
5. Follow up on a schedule; record every deal in a CRM.
6. Review won and lost deals monthly to improve messaging and offers.

EXAMPLE CODE / TEMPLATE

```
OUTREACH MESSAGE (LinkedIn / email)
Hi Priya, I noticed Sharma Realty lists 300+ properties across 3 portals. Agencies we work with often
take 3-4 hours to reply to portal leads, and most buyers choose whoever replies first.
We set up a system that replies to every lead in under a minute with matching listings and books
site visits automatically. Would a 15-minute call next week to see if it fits your team be useful?

OBJECTION: 'It's too expensive.'
Response: 'Understood. Can we look at the numbers together? If the system converts 3 extra leads a
month at your average commission, how does that compare with the monthly cost?' (use their figures)

PIPELINE STAGES
Target → Contacted → Discovery done → Demo done → Proposal sent → Negotiation → Won / Lost
(reason)
```

COMMON MISTAKES

- Generic messages sent to everyone.
- Talking about technology instead of their outcome.
- Not qualifying budget and decision-maker.

- Overpromising results or timelines.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q. How do you sell to a sceptical buyer who tried an AI tool that failed?

A. Ask what failed and why, acknowledge it, propose a small paid pilot with clear success metrics on their data, show evidence from similar clients, and include safeguards and easy exit terms.

Q. What is your process after a 'no'?

A. Ask for the reason, record it, keep in touch with useful content, and revisit when circumstances change; use patterns in lost reasons to improve the offer.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

> Run a 30-day outreach experiment: 50 targeted prospects, track replies, calls, proposals and wins in a CRM, and write what you learned.

OFFICIAL AND RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- HubSpot Academy: sales courses https://academy.hubspot.com/
- Y Combinator: sales for founders https://www.ycombinator.com/library/6c-sales-for-founders
- HubSpot CRM (free) https://www.hubspot.com/products/crm